

Hopes For Big Year



WALKER COOPER, new Indianapolis manager is pictured at Victory Field calling for a pitch from one of his young moundsmen. Both the parent Chicago White Sox, who assigned a number of young hurlers to Indianapolis for development, and the Indians' front office board of strategy, are counting on the Hall of Fame catcher to improve the club's pitching — a weak spot in 1957.

Cooper Makes Bow at Victory Field Tonight

An old and a new rivalry will be launched at Victory Field tonight as the Indians match runs with Denver in a 7:45 contest which will see "Hall of Famer" Walker Cooper in his debut as a pilot, matching wits with the Bears' Andy Cohen who did an unsuccessful job of plotting the Indians' strategy last season.

Cohen was the object of much second-guessing in 1957 and fans frequently felt he got into rhubarbs with the umpires to cover the fact that his master-minding had backfired. His dismissal was welcomed in many quarters and fans were surprised when he was later taken on by the proud Yankees to manage their top form club.

Cooper has always been popular, with fans and players alike, and the Victory Field faithful will be adding a prayer to their hopes the first time the big field manager steps to the plate against Cohen's club.

The powerful catcher will be behind the plate himself tonight, and his presence alone is expected to draw a large crowd to the stadium. An Indianapolis business firm has purchased a live bear for the Indians, with the provision that the animal will go to Denver when it defeats Indianapolis. The bear, the players and officials will take part in a mammoth parade through downtown Indianapolis, before the game officially gets underway with a brief ceremony at the ball park at 7:45.

Barry Lattman has already been named to take the hill for the season opener after convincing Cooper of his readiness with a nine-inning performance last week. Jim Derington, an 18-year-old bonus pitcher belonging to the White Sox, is likely to take the mound for the second game of the series Wednesday evening.

Of good news to Indians' followers was word released yesterday that Sam Mele, veteran major league outfielder and longball hitter, had agreed to terms with the club after a conference with Cooper. Mele had been a holdout all spring following a salary dispute with club officials, and probably will not break into the opening night lineup which is expected to be John Callison, Joe Hicks and Bob Hale.

Joe Althobelli, last year with Cleveland, will likely start at first, Charley Williams at second, Bobby Winkles at short and Vince Garcia at third. Garcia, who wound up last season with a .298 batting average, ninth highest in the league, has been converted from second base to third, in an effort to plug a weakness there, but his transfer leaves the Indians with a weakness in the double-play department, and Tribe general manager Ray Johnston has been trying all spring to swing a deal with Washington or one of the other major league clubs for a fast pivot man who can also wield a little power at the plate. Winkles was named the outstanding shortstop of the Texas League last year at Tulsa, while batting .279, and while he's making a big jump to tripple-A ball, Cooper may be able to help him get the power he needs into his blows.

Sam Hairston will probably be behind the plate when Cooper is not catching until young Johnny Romano gets back in condition after six months in the Army. Hairston has done well behind the plate this spring, and was one of the clubs top hitters down south.

SPLIT DECISION

NEW YORK (INS) — Middle-